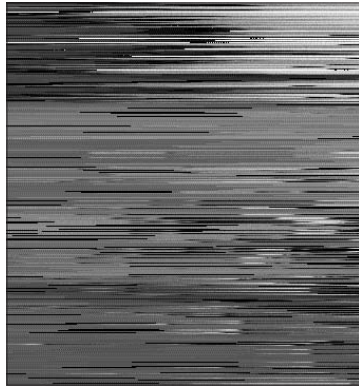


documented in the *GNU General Public License*, or GPL. Stallman himself developed some free software such as the GNU C compiler, and GNU Emacs. (Emacs is a text editor and interpreter for Emacs Lisp, which is a version of the Lisp Programming language.)



Richard Stallman

Several discussions and debates have taken place amongst representatives of commercial vs. open-source, free software. Microsoft, too, has participated in a common platform discussion on the subject along with Linux distributors. But the two are as far apart as can be. Microsoft (we can't leave them out in any discussion, can we?) believes in commercial software as its business model. Open source fans are wary of monopolisation, and say that sharing of technologies is the right way to go about building the Internet. In the words of Michael Tiemann, Ex CTO and current Vice President, Open Source of Red Hat:

*"The stakes are very high in how we construct the future of the Internet. Do we want a winner-takes-all scenario for whichever company ultimately creates that particular piece of intellectual property that maximizes interoperability (across systems) or do we want to create a commons?"*

Microsoft, in trying shrug off its monopolistic and "closed" image, has taken a small step in opening up its vast share pool of source code. It has "opened" some of its software code on select products under a Shared Source License. But the License clearly states that users can experiment for non-commercial purposes only. This means if someone figures out a way of making their software better by modifying the source code, he cannot distribute it. But well, perhaps something is better than nothing!